



Building Activism

The architecture of democracy," a British magazine called it. On April 27, 1968 – the year of the assassinations of Martin Luther King Jr. and Robert Kennedy, the year of street violence at the Democratic convention in Chicago – neighborhood activists marched onto a parking lot on Dartmouth Street in the South End and took it over, erecting tents and sheds. They called their encampment Tent City. They believed that the South End should be building affordable housing, not parking lots.

The old photo shows that original protest. For the most part it was a cheerful, 1960s-style event. People played guitars and supped on food supplied by sympathizers. According to the *Globe*, the site "took on the festive air of a gypsy camp, as several dozen anti-urban renewal demonstrators . . . [pitched] tents, stringing lights, throwing up shacks made of scrap lumber, and even putting

out a Rural Free Delivery mailbox." The police left them alone. At the end of the weekend, they departed peacefully.

It took 20 years, but the activists got what they wanted. They never gave up. They formed the Tent City Corporation. They lobbied and politicked. They picketed again in 1981, when it was announced that the site would hold a parking garage for Copley Place, next door. Eventually, a deal was struck. The garage would be built, but it would be underground. Affordable housing would, at last, be constructed above it. The new development opened in 1988. In honor of its origins, it was named Tent City.

In the new photo, Tent City is the cluster of low buildings in the foreground. There are 269 apartments, of which three-quarters are subsidized for low- or moderate-income tenants. Behind Tent City, in vivid contrast, is a somewhat frenzied skyline of capitalist development, with the vast Prudential

Center on the left and Copley Place on the right.

Tent City's architects were a Boston firm called Goody Clancy that sought to make architecture that would fit comfortably into the South End without literally copying tradition. Shaping the complex around a handsome green quad, they played modern riffs on such Victorian motifs as mansard roofs, triangular pediments, bay windows, front stoops, and even a couple of pointy-headed corner towers. The result doesn't have the mass or craftsmanship of the old South End buildings, and thus the complex looks a little stagy. But as Paul Goldberger wrote at the time in *The New York Times*, "There is wisdom in accepting the traditional and common elements of the existing city," rather than reinventing the wheel every time around.

Tent City Corporation didn't quit with Tent City; it continues to develop affordable housing in the South End. **BC**

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